military expedition to Afghanistan with the direct, if secret, sanction of Bentinck himself.

As late as 1828, the Governor General had refused pleas from Shah Shuja even to be granted an interview. Now the Persian threat to Herat, and Ellenborough's determination to resist the Russians, had changed political calculations. Bentinck now ruled that, while the British official position would remain one of studied neutrality, Shah Shuja would be allowed discreet help to mount his expedition, including a four-month advance on his pension – a total of 16,000 rupees.[81]

The very same month, while Dost Mohammad Khan was receiving friendly messages from Bentinck thanking him for his hospitality to Burnes and expressing his 'deep desire that friendship and union should be established between this Government and yourself', Bentinck's new Private Secretary, William Macnaghten, was secretly instructing Fraser not only to release Shuja's arms dealers from jail, but also to waive all duty for their purchases at the Delhi Customs, so facilitating a Sadozai counter-revolution against the Barakzai government.[82]

Macnaghten, the man behind this new covert operation, was a bookish orientalist and former judge from Ulster who had been promoted from his court room to run the Company's bureaucracy. Originally a protégé of Henry Russell, the smooth and ambitious Resident at Hyderabad, he was widely respected for his intelligence, but many disliked his pompous, preening vanity while others questioned whether this 'man of the desk' was at all suited to his new job as private secretary and chief adviser to the Governor General.[k] Macnaghten, by contrast, had absolutely no doubts about his own abilities, and instead rather fancied his facility for political intrigue. He also believed he knew Afghanistan far better than he actually did, although he had never been anywhere near the region and all he knew came from his reading of Wade's despatches. Like Wade, Macnaghten may also have been slightly jealous of Burnes's rapid rise: as a born bureaucrat who always wished to maintain the existing protocol, he disapproved of the way Burnes had managed to reach the ear of the Governor General and the Cabinet in London without going through the usual channels. He had also known Wade for many years, liked him, trusted his judgement and approved of the more conventional way he worked and thought.

So was born a dangerously contradictory and two-faced British policy towards Afghanistan, with Burnes making friendly overtures to Dost